Psalm 119:145-152 "I Cried Out With All My Heart"

Intro:
The section we are studying this week — *Qoph* — is centered on prayer, *specifically prayer for* ***obedience***. In a psalm entirely devoted to the Word of God, it might seem surprising to find a section so focused on prayer. But it is not off-topic at all — it is perfectly fitting. Psalm 119 is not merely about reading Scripture — it is about living it. And living it requires prayer. Throughout Psalm 119 we see constant mentions of prayer, in fact the psalms are just that, prayers. This shows us that prayer and Scripture are inseparable. Prayer and the study of God's Word are both essential parts of each other. So as the psalmist shelters himself from sin and seeks to be transformed by the Word, he also holds on to prayer, begging God to use His Word to continue to transform and renew Him; with the purpose of living a more God centered obedient life. As we observe this section we will observe (1.) *what prayer truly is*, (2.) *how it should be practiced*, and (3.) *why it is necessary* — especially when the goal is obedience.

V.145-146
"**I cried with all my heart**; answer me, O Lord! *I will observe Your statutes*. **I cried to You**; save me *And I shall keep Your testimonies*."

WHAT IS PRAYER: **A Cry From The Whole Heart:**
The Word the psalmist uses to describe his prayer is *"cry out"*. The Hebrew word "qara" carries intensity and desperation and also suggests that the prayer is vocal. When paired with the phrase "with all my heart," it shows us that the psalmist does not pray casually or in a routine manner but sincerely, desperately, and wholeheartedly. Praying sincerely with your whole heart is more important than praying long or eloquently. And what is striking is what he is crying for. He is crying out for obedience. "Save me, and I shall keep Your testimonies." He is not merely asking for relief; he is asking to be rescued from himself. He understands that his greatest enemy is not merely outside pressure but inward weakness. He knows he needs deliverance from himself. The fact that he repeats the cry for obedience shows us the emphasis and urgency of this request.

V.147-148
"**I rise before dawn** *and cry for help*; **I wait for Your words**. **My eyes anticipate the night watches**, *That I may meditate on Your word*."

HOW SHOULD WE PRAY: **With Participation & Effort:**
"I rise before dawn" - The psalmist is not just "wishing" for obedience but truly pursuing it with faith through prayer. He proves this by waking up before the sun rises to cry out in prayer. He structures his life around seeking God. His hope in the Word ("I wait for Your words") is not passive. It is active, intentional trust demonstrated by sacrificing time and comfort to pray for obedience and transformation.

"My eyes anticipate the night watch"- What the psalmist is saying is that he would look forward to and stay up through the middle of the night to spend time meditating on the Word of God in the still and quite. So not only did he wake up early to seek God but he also stayed up late top do so. He estimated that there were seasons where time in the Word mattered more than sleep. This does not mean legalism — it reveals longing. He is not earning grace, but participating in it. He understands that growth in obedience requires effort, discipline, and consistency. He is not casually glancing at Scripture; he is unfolding it, meditating on it, and shaping his life around it.

V.149-152
"*Hear my voice* **according to Your lovingkindness**; *Revive me, O Lord*, **according to Your ordinances** (justice). **Those who follow after wickedness draw near**; *They are far from Your law*. **You are near, O Lord**, And *all Your commandments are truth*. **Of old I have known from Your testimonies That You have founded them forever**."

PSALM 119

WHY SHOULD WE PRAY?

1. **Because God Is Loving And Merciful:** Though the psalmist puts in effort, he does not appeal to God on the basis of his discipline. He appeals to God's lovingkindness — His steadfast covenant love. The psalmist does not ask God to hear him because of anything good he could've done, he understands his sinful and rebellious nature, which is exactly why he's crying out, instead he ask God to hear him simply because he knows God is full of love and mercy. He understands that waking early and staying up late earns him nothing. His hope is not in his performance but in God's character. True prayer rests on grace.

2. **Because God is just:** When the psalmist appeals to God's justice, we now understand this through Christ. For us, to appeal to God's justice is to appeal to the justice-satisfying work of Jesus. We pray as forgiven children whose debt has already been paid. Hebrews 4:16 reminds us to draw near with confidence, not because we deserve it, but because Christ has satisfied justice on our behalf. We ask for revival not from a place of condemnation, but from a place of reconciliation.

3. **Because Wicked Influence Draws Near:** The psalmist acknowledges reality: those who follow wickedness draw near. The pressure of the world is real. Its influence presses in. This is precisely why prayer is necessary. Obedience does not happen in isolation from opposition. In a world increasingly shaped by sin, its influence will always attempt to creep closer. Prayer becomes essential because the battle is constant.

4. **Because God Is Nearer:** Yet in the same breath, he declares, "You are near, O Lord." The world may draw near — but God is nearer. This is the comfort that steadies him. He does not deny the pressure, but he also does not forget God's presence. His confidence in prayer rests in the nearness of God that he has experienced in a scriptural relationship with God.

5. **To Grow In Intimacy And Love With God:** "*The Psalmist had an "old" relationship with God. The love and appreciation we have seen the psalmist have for the Lord and His Word throughout all of Psalm 119, was not a youthful surge of infatuation. It was a deep settled love with roots that grew stronger because of time"* - David Guzik. As we pursue our God through the Word and prayer, our love and intimacy with Him grows and grows throughout time so much so that we develop the confidence the psalmist had in God's Word. Knowing fully that it is eternal and true. See, love deepens over time. If we want this kind of intimacy and love for God we need to not only give minutes of our day to God, ***but years of our life***. And as the years go by you will see your soul proclaim the same truths, love, and confidence in God and His Word.

Conclusion and Main Idea:
As we mentioned last week, Jesus is our perfect example and model of this. Being God Himself, He modeled for us what it is to be dependent in prayer. Being God in the flesh, He also spent "night watches" praying (Luke 6:12), woke up before dawn to pray (Mark 1:35), and through anguish strengthened his obedience in prayer (Luke 22:41-44).

Memory verse:
"I cried with all my heart; answer me, O Lord! I will observe Your statutes."
Psalms 119:145 NASB1995

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